

Leopoldstadt district of Vienna in 1874. He began violin lessons at the age of eight and invented short pieces for himself and friends to play. Arnold learned the basics of composition by reading books and imitating other people's music. After his father died in 1890, he worked in a bank for five years to help support the family. He also played cello in an amateur orchestra set up by another young musician, Alexander Zemlinsky, who gave Schoenberg his only lessons in composition and became a lifelong friend.

German cultural traditions

Schoenberg aligned himself with the great tradition of German music, from Brahms and Wagner to Mozart and Bach. In 1898, to further identify with German culture, he gave up his Jewish faith in favor of Lutheran Christianity. He adopted a Romantic view of the composer as a divinely inspired prophet with spiritual responsibilities, an attitude that precluded concern for music as entertainment.

His first composition performed in public was a string quartet premiered in Vienna in 1897. This was well received, but thereafter his work met with incomprehension and abuse. His *Verklärte Nacht*, originally written for a string sextet, appears in retrospect an accessible, ravishing example of late Romanticism, but in 1899 its chromaticism puzzled even open-minded Viennese music enthusiasts. Hugely ambitious, in the early 1900s Schoenberg worked on a vast Wagnerian cantata, *Gurre-Lieder*, and a large-scale orchestral tone poem, *Pelleas und Melisande*. His efforts were privately encouraged by prominent composers